Welcome to Piano Lessons

Dear Parents and Families,

I'm so pleased to be welcoming your child to piano lessons, and I'm looking forward to sharing the wonderful world of music with them.

Learning an instrument is such a special experience. When you are just starting out, it is about much more than learning which keys to press or how to read notes. It's about discovering sounds, developing curiosity, building confidence, learning to listen and experiencing the excitement of being able to make music.

Every learner comes to the piano with their own personality, interests and way of learning. I have found that some love to sing, some want to play everything as quickly as possible, some enjoy patterns and puzzles, and others simply love exploring the sounds of the instrument. I like to encourage all of these things! My aim is to make lessons a happy, encouraging and creative experience where children feel comfortable trying new things, making mistakes, asking questions and celebrating their progress.

I have outlined some information about getting started below, which I hope you will find helpful.

1. What to bring along to lessons

Students will need to bring a couple of things to lessons.

The first is a display book that can accommodate the A4 sheets of paper I will be providing (something like this one from Officeworks) (1). No particular brand is needed, just something that can store A4 paper and sit easily on a music stand.

The second is a small exercise book so we can record homework and notes about what we are working on. I find a small A5 book is great. Some students prefer a hardbound book and like that diary feel, while others are happy with a school exercise book.

I also tend to encourage students to create some music-related cover art for both of these, which they usually enjoy!

2. Practising for just 10 minutes a day makes a difference

A little bit of piano every day is far more valuable than one long practice session each week.

For young beginners, around 10 minutes a day is a wonderful starting point. For some children, especially at the beginning, even five happy, focused minutes is a success.

Regular practice helps children remember what they've learned, develop coordination, become familiar with the keyboard and gradually feel more confident.

It doesn't need to be a formal or serious occasion. In fact, the more relaxed and enjoyable it feels, the better.

Some tips for effective practice:

- Find a regular time each day, perhaps after school, before dinner or as part of the evening routine.
- Keep the piano or keyboard somewhere your child can easily access it (2).
- Encourage your child to show you something they learned in their lesson.
- Celebrate achievements, even if it's just finding a note or playing a short pattern.
- Keep practice positive. If your child is tired or frustrated, it's perfectly fine to come back to it later.

The goal should always be to build a happy, lasting relationship with music.

3. Listening is just as important as playing

One of the loveliest ways to support your child's musical development is simply to listen to music together.

Children learn an enormous amount through listening. They begin to recognise melodies, rhythms, patterns, different instruments and the many ways music can express feelings and tell stories.

From my own experience, there will come a time when your child will take over the music in your car! So share the music you love while you can! Sing together, clap along to a favourite song, dance in the kitchen or ask your child what they notice in a piece of music.

Great questions to ask young learners:

- Does this music sound happy, sad, exciting or peaceful?
- Can you hear the piano?
- Is the music fast or slow?
- Can you clap along with the beat?
- What was your favourite sound?

There are no wrong answers to many of these questions. It's about helping children become curious and attentive listeners.

4. Playing for other people is key

Music is fundamentally about connection. It is about sharing ideas, emotions and experiences with others. Learning to play for others is therefore an important part of musical development, not simply something we do once we've mastered an instrument. Many of the adult learners I work with struggle with stage fright or performance anxiety, sometimes shaped by negative experiences earlier in life. Research (3) highlights how difficult performance experiences during childhood and adolescence can contribute to the development of music performance anxiety.

This is why I believe it's so important to make sharing music a positive experience from the very beginning. For some children, this will be a gradual process, perhaps starting with playing something for a parent or family member, while others will be eager to jump straight in. The important thing is to encourage children at their own pace, helping them discover that playing music is not about being perfect, but about the joy of sharing something with others.

5. Learning resources

I have collected a lot of resources over the years to teach students of all ages and levels. These include all kinds of worksheets and activities to support what we explore during lessons. They cover topics ranging from developing instrumental skills to music theory, composing music for orchestras, jazz harmony and analysis, and Carnatic rhythm practices.

All of the resources I provide are also available on my website:

https://jamiegabriel.org/teaching.html

There, you will be able to find copies of the materials your child is working on, revisit activities we've covered and use them to support practice at home.

For beginners, I like to create variety in lessons, so we will mix playing, listening, worksheets, interactive games and learning songs as different ways of exploring music. As students progress, I tend to introduce repertoire from AMEB or Trinity College, which provides a graded approach towards formal music qualifications. Some students like to work towards piano grades, while others don't, but either way, it's a nice way to explore lots of different piano music.

6. About me

Music has been a central part of my life for many years, both personally and professionally. I'm a multi-instrumentalist, performer, composer and educator, with

extensive experience across jazz piano and guitar, classical music, contemporary styles, and modern experimental and soundscape music. I've performed in jazz ensembles, composed and recorded original music, and taught music from school to university level. I also hold a PhD in computational musicology, where my research involved developing computational models for analysing musical scores.

Alongside my musical career, I have a strong background in computer science and mathematics, and have held senior technology roles in corporate and government organisations. In 2023, I moved from Sydney to the Lake Macquarie area to focus on music, and I have also undertaken postgraduate training as a school teacher. I continue to perform, compose and record both locally and internationally, including with my own ensembles and SAJA Project, a collaborative music project with my partner, Sally (who has also developed many of the teaching resources I use). We live between Australia and New Zealand and have been performing music together since we met at music school as teenagers.

These experiences have given me a broad musical perspective, from the traditions of classical and jazz performance to the creative possibilities of improvisation, traditional composition and electronic music. I enjoy bringing this diversity into my teaching and introducing children to the wonderful range of sounds, styles and ideas that music has to offer.

The thing I like most about teaching is helping learners develop a genuine enjoyment of music. I love finding creative ways to make musical ideas understandable, interesting and fun, while gradually building the skills, confidence and independence that come with learning an instrument.

Jamie Gabriel

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Notes

1. https://www.officeworks.com.au/shop/officeworks/p/j-burrows-refillable-display-book-40-pockets-clear-jbrrfdb40c

2. I have found that, especially when starting out, families may not have ready access to a keyboard, particularly while deciding whether piano is something their child would like to pursue. Many of the beginning exercises I provide will also be in the form of worksheets, including printable keyboards, finger exercises and simple music activities that children can practise away from the piano. While having access to a keyboard will become increasingly important as lessons progress, there is still plenty we can do in the early stages to develop musical understanding, coordination and confidence without one.

3. Osborne, M. S., & Kenny, D. T. (2008). The role of sensitizing experiences in music performance anxiety in adolescent musicians. Psychology of Music, 36(4), 447–462. https://doi.org/10.1177/0305735607086051.